

Recognising Women Farmers in India



For Prelims: International Year of the Woman Farmer , United Nations , PM-KISAN scheme , Food and Agriculture Organization , Kisan Credit Cards

For Mains: Feminisation of agriculture and changing patterns of women's workforce participation, Role of women in rural transformation and agricultural development.

Source: TH

Why in News?

Maharashtra recently became the first Indian state to pass the **Women Farmers Empowerment Bill, 2026** , which grants women independent legal recognition as farmers through a ' **Woman Farmer Certificate** ,' irrespective of land ownership.

- This historic legislation aligns with the **United Nations designating 2026 as the International Year of the Woman Farmer** , bringing global and national focus to the systemic exclusion of the female agricultural workforce from formal welfare schemes.

Summary

- **Maharashtra's Women Farmers Empowerment Bill, 2026** seeks to recognise women as farmers irrespective of land ownership through a **Woman Farmer Certificate** , addressing gaps in land ownership, farmer databases and access to agricultural schemes.
- Strengthening **activity-based farmer recognition, institutional credit, Agri Stack integration, women FPOs and local governance** can improve women's access to resources and advance **gender equality, food security and inclusive agricultural development** .

What is the Status of Women in Indian Agriculture?

- **Workforce Participation:** The Indian agricultural sector is undergoing a massive demographic shift,

widely termed the " **feminisation of agriculture** (growing role and reliance on women in farming and rural economies) ."

- According to the **Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2023-24** , over **76.95% of rural working women** are engaged in agriculture and allied activities, making it the largest employer for women.
- **The Ownership Paradox:** Women remain underrepresented in land ownership. According to the **Agricultural Census 2015-16, only 14% of operational agricultural land holdings were held by women** .
 - Moreover, only **12.8% of women had ownership or legal rights over agricultural land** .
- **Scheme Exclusion:** Because welfare schemes use **land records as the sole metric to identify farmers**, women are systemically excluded. For instance, women constitute only **23% of beneficiaries** under the **PM-KISAN scheme** nationally.
- **High Incidence of Unpaid Labor:** In 2025, despite nearing gender parity in raw workforce numbers (roughly 110 million women to 127 million men), over **41% of female agricultural workers are classified as unpaid helpers** in family enterprises, compared to just 20% of men.
 - Conversely, **nearly 63% of men were own-account workers, compared with only 39% of women.**
 - Thus, despite women's growing participation in agriculture, their limited economic recognition and ownership continue to create a significant recognition gap.

Factors Driving the Feminisation of Agriculture in India

Economic Forces

- **Male Distress Out-Migration:** Agrarian distress and stagnant farm incomes push rural men toward **non-farm urban sectors** (e.g., construction, manufacturing) for higher wages, leaving family farm management to women.
 - **Covid-19** triggered massive urban job losses and reverse migration of men to rural areas. The return of men often shifted land control and key farming decisions back to them, pushing women into marginalised and unpaid agricultural labour.
- **Cost-Cutting via Wage Disparity:** High input costs induce landowners to employ women as casual agricultural labourers, as patriarchal wage structures allow them to be **paid 20-30% less than male counterparts**.
 - Economic distress compels small and marginal farmer households to **substitute paid hired labour** with unpaid female household labour to preserve profit margins.
- **Lack of Rural Non-Farm Alternatives:** Poor rural industrialisation and lower formal educational/vocational training for **women restrict them from accessing non-farm rural employment**, confining them to primary sector work.

Socio-Cultural Forces

- **Spatial Immobility and Care Burden:** Social norms designate women as primary **caregivers for children, the elderly, and livestock, anchoring them to the village while men migrate**.
- **Cultural Perceptions of Farm Work:** Labour-intensive farm operations (transplanting, weeding, harvesting) are culturally treated as extensions of domestic chores, making **agricultural tasks socially acceptable for women**.
- **Patriarchal Barriers to Migration:** Safety concerns, social surveillance, and caste/community taboos **discourage women from independently migrating to cities for livelihood opportunities**.
- **Lack of Property Rights:** Customary inheritance norms favor male lineage, leaving women landless and trapped in informal subsistence agriculture without the assets or collateral needed to transition into entrepreneurship.

Why is it Crucial to Recognise Women as Farmers?

- **Ensuring Food Security:** The **Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO)** estimates that if women farmers had the same access to productive resources as men, agricultural yields could increase by **20% to 30%**, potentially reducing global **hunger for 100-150 million people**.
- **Household Wellbeing and Nutrition:** Recognizing women as independent economic actors gives them greater control over agricultural income.
 - Women are statistically more likely to **reinvest earnings into household nutrition, healthcare, and education**.
- **Climate-Smart Agriculture:** Women hold significant indigenous knowledge regarding traditional **seed**

preservation, biodiversity, and soil management .

- Empowering them is critical for building resilience against climate change and adopting sustainable practices.

What are the Major Challenges Faced by Women Farmers?

- **The Worker-Owner Dichotomy:** Patriarchal **inheritance norms** dictate that land is usually registered in a man's name. Because state mechanisms **define a "farmer" based on land titles, women are rendered statistically invisible.**
- **Lack of Institutional Credit:** Without land to serve as collateral, women cannot easily access formal banking services, **Kisan Credit Cards (KCC)** , or **affordable agricultural loans, forcing them to rely on informal money lenders.**
- **Exclusion from State Welfare:** Essential support mechanisms such as subsidized **fertilizers, seeds, crop insurance (PMFBY)** , and extension services are channeled through land records, bypassing female cultivators entirely.
- **Gender Bias in Mechanization:** Most modern agricultural machinery is designed for **male ergonomics.**
 - The lack of lightweight, gender-sensitive farming technology increases the physical drudgery for women.
- **Poor Market Access:** Social constraints, lack of transportation, and male-dominated **APMC mandis restrict women from negotiating fair prices for their produce, leaving them vulnerable to middlemen.**

India's Initiatives Related to Women Farmers

- **Mahila Kisan Sashaktikaran Pariyojana (MKSP):** A sub-component of the **DAY-NRLM scheme** that seeks to improve the skills and capacities of women in agriculture to enhance their participation and productivity.
- **Krishi Sakhi Convergence Program (KSCP):** Linked with the ' **Lakshpati Didi** ' initiative, this program trains rural women as **Community Agriculture Care Service** Providers to deliver last-mile agricultural advisory services.
- **Earmarked Allocations:** The Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare mandates that at least **30% of the budget allocation** for various central schemes and programs is reserved for women farmers.
- **Promotion of Women FPOs:** The government is actively promoting the creation of **Farmer Producer Organizations (FPOs)** exclusively for women to improve their bargaining power and market integration.
- **Uttar Pradesh:** The UP Government provides a **1% stamp duty concession** on property or agricultural land registered in a woman's name to promote **female land ownership** .

What Measures Can Empower Women Farmers in

India?

- **De-linking Farmer Status from Land Ownership:** States should replicate Maharashtra's model by introducing activity-based definitions of farming. Issuing legal "Woman Farmer Certificates" through local **Gram Sabhas** can help landless cultivators, sharecroppers, and laborers access state benefits.
- **Creating Interoperable Databases:** Standardizing the definition of a woman farmer across states and integrating this data with **Agri Stack** will create a unified digital registry, enabling direct benefit transfers and unique FarmerIDs.
- **Expanding Collateral-Free Credit:** Financial institutions and **NABARD** should formally recognize activity-based farming certificates as valid documents to disburse zero-collateral agricultural credit and **Kisan Credit Cards** to women.
- **Strengthening Local Governance:** Empowering Gram Panchayats and local institutions is crucial for generating awareness, facilitating the certification process, and embedding women's agricultural priorities into **Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDs)**.
- **Gender-Responsive Budgeting and Audits:** State governments must conduct strict annual audits to ensure that the mandated 30% allocation in agricultural subsidies directly reaches certified women farmers on the ground.

Conclusion

Bridging the women farmer recognition gap by delinking farmer identity from land ownership can improve access to agricultural schemes, credit, technology and welfare benefits. It can also advance **SDG 5 (Gender Equality), SDG 1 (No Poverty) and SDG 2 (Zero Hunger)**.

As 2026 marks the International Year of the Woman Farmer, scaling Maharashtra's activity-based farmer recognition model across States can ensure that women engaged in farming are formally recognised, included in agricultural databases and empowered as equal participants in India's agricultural economy.

Drishti Mains Question:

"The feminisation of Indian agriculture has not been accompanied by a corresponding feminisation of land ownership." Discuss the structural factors behind this paradox.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Women Farmers Empowerment Bill, 2026?

It is a Maharashtra legislation that seeks to provide **independent legal recognition to women as farmers irrespective of land ownership** through a **Woman Farmer Certificate** .

2. Why are women farmers often excluded from agricultural welfare schemes?

Many agricultural schemes rely on **land records for farmer identification** , disadvantaging women who cultivate family land but do not have land titles in their names.

3. What is Mahila Kisan Sashaktikaran Pariyojana (MKSP)?

MKSP is a component of DAY-NRLM aimed at enhancing the **skills, capacities and participation of rural women in agriculture** and improving their productivity.

4. What is the Krishi Sakhi Convergence Program?

The **Krishi Sakhi Convergence Program** trains rural women as **Community Agriculture Care Service Providers** , enabling them to deliver **last-mile agricultural advisory services** .

5. How can women farmer recognition improve agricultural empowerment?

Linking **Woman Farmer Certificates with Farmer IDs, Agri Stack, institutional credit, subsidies and extension services** can improve women's access to agricultural resources and strengthen their economic empowerment.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/18qaEqhLYxg](https://www.youtube.com/embed/18qaEqhLYxg)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims :

Q. With reference to the circumstances in Indian agriculture, the concept of “Conservation Agriculture” assumes significance. Which of the following fall under the Conservation Agriculture? (2018)

1. Avoiding the monoculture practices
2. Adopting minimum tillage.
3. Avoiding the cultivation of plantation crops
4. Using crop residues to cover soil surface
5. Adopting spatial and temporal crop sequencing/crop rotations

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 3 and 4
- (b) 2, 3, 4 and 5
- (c) 2, 4 and 5
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 5

Ans: (c)

Mains :

Q. Discuss the various economic and socio-cultural forces that are driving increasing feminization of agriculture in India. (2014)

G20 Nations Adopt 4 Consensus Outcomes on Energy, Water and Critical Minerals



Source: AIR

India joined other **G20 members** in adopting four consensus outcomes at the **G20 Energy Abundance Ministerial held in Houston, Texas** , focusing on **household energy access, infrastructure approvals, water reuse and critical mineral supply chains** .

- **Household Energy Access:** G20 members supported affordable and scalable clean cooking solutions, including **liquefied petroleum gas (LPG)** as an option to replace traditional biomass in developing countries where LPG can be reliably expanded.
- **Infrastructure Permitting Reforms:** Countries agreed to promote **efficient, predictable and effective domestic permitting and regulatory processes** to accelerate energy infrastructure projects.
- **Water Reuse Initiative:** G20 launched a **voluntary water-reuse initiative** to encourage recycling and reuse of water across sectors such as **communities, agriculture, manufacturing and energy production** , based on water quality and intended use.
- **Critical Mineral Supply Chains:** Members agreed to voluntary cooperation for creating **secure, affordable and diversified critical mineral value chains** through **information sharing, innovation, investment, capacity building and local value addition** .
- **Nature of Commitments:** The G20 outcomes are **consensus-based political commitments and not legally binding treaties** ; their implementation depends on the domestic policies, regulations and investments of participating countries.
- **Significance:** The outcomes align with India's priorities in **clean cooking fuel expansion, infrastructure development, water conservation and securing critical minerals** required for sectors such as **electronics, renewable energy and advanced manufacturing** .

Read More: [G20 Johannesburg Summit 2025](#)

RBI's Forex Swap Facility and VRRR Operations



Source: AIR

In a strategic move to stabilize the weakening domestic currency and manage money markets, the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** successfully mobilized over USD 143.5 billion through its **special forex swap facility** while simultaneously deploying absorption tools to handle the resulting Rs 4.92 lakh crore systemic cash surplus.

- **Special Forex Swap Facility:** Launched by the **RBI in June 2026**, the facility allows commercial banks to **swap foreign-currency inflows**, such as **Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) (FCNR(B)) deposits** and **External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs)**, with the RBI for rupees, while protecting them from exchange-rate risk.
 - It aims to **encourage US-dollar inflows, improve dollar liquidity in the forex market, and help curb depreciation of the rupee**.
- **Composition of Forex Inflows:** Out of the USD 143.5 billion received by September 2026, the overwhelming majority came through **FCNR(B) deposits** (USD 132 billion), with the rest contributed by **Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs)** and **External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs)**.
- **Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR) Auction:** To manage the massive cash flush, the RBI conducted an **overnight VRRR auction**, successfully absorbing Rs 71,971 crore from the banking system.
 - The VRRR auction is a monetary policy tool utilized by the RBI under its **Liquidity Adjustment Facility (LAF)**. Its primary objective is to absorb excess funds from the **banking system for a specific duration** to ensure short-term, overnight money market rates align with the **benchmark policy repo rate**.
 - Unlike fixed-rate reverse repos, the interest rate in a VRRR auction is determined through competitive bidding by commercial banks.
- **Open Market Operations (OMO):** Alongside VRRR, the RBI is utilizing OMOs to permanently drain rupee liquidity from the banking system by conducting sales of **Government securities**.

Read more: [India's Record Forex Reserves: FCNR\(B\) Swap Facility](#)

Northeast India's Largest Thermal Power Project



Source: TH

Recently, the **Assam Chief Minister** laid the foundation stone for the Northeast's largest power project at **Chapar, Dhubri district** .

- Once completed, it will become the **largest power project in Northeast India by installed capacity** , surpassing the **2,000 MW Subansiri Lower Hydroelectric Project** .
- **About:** The project is a **3,200 MW Ultra-Supercritical Thermal Power Plant** being developed by Adani Power Ltd. with an investment of ₹48,000 crore. Commissioning of the thermal power plant is planned in phases from December 2030.
- **Technology:** The project will use **ultra-supercritical technology** , which improves efficiency through higher operating temperatures and pressures while incorporating modern environmental safeguards.
- **Energy Significance:** The plant aims to provide **reliable and affordable electricity** for households, industries and businesses. It is expected to strengthen Assam's position as an **energy hub in Northeast India** .
- **Economic Impact:** The project is expected to generate employment opportunities and promote local industries, contractors and suppliers. Assam is expected to benefit through increased economic activity and **State GST (SGST) revenues** .

Read More: [Balancing Sustainable Energy Goals with Coal Realities](#)

US, Denmark and Greenland Sign Agreement on Arctic Security



Source: TH

Recently, the **US, Denmark and Greenland** signed a **trilateral agreement** on the sidelines of the **UN General Assembly** in New York to enhance **Arctic and North Atlantic security cooperation**.

- **About:** The agreement **amends the 1951 US-Denmark Defense Agreement on Greenland** and aims to strengthen defence cooperation while respecting Greenland's sovereignty and self-determination.

- **Military Infrastructure:** The agreement allows the **US to modernise and expand activities at Pituffik Space Base** and establish additional defence areas at **Narsarsuaq** and **Mestersvig** in Greenland.
- **Defence Capabilities:** The agreement provides the US military wider access to Greenland, including movement of aircraft, vessels and undersea access, and allows defence cooperation including the possible establishment of the “ **Golden Dome** ” **missile defence system** .
- **NATO and Arctic Security:** The agreement supports stronger **NATO engagement in the Arctic** through enhanced planning, military presence, exercises and intelligence cooperation.
- **Security Safeguards:** The agreement restricts **non-NATO military presence** in Greenland and prevents foreign control or influence in sensitive sectors, including **critical infrastructure and resource extraction** .
- **Strategic Significance:** Greenland’s **Arctic location, proximity to North America and Europe, resource potential, emerging shipping routes and strategic importance amid growing competition involving major powers such as Russia and China** make it a key region for Arctic security and geopolitics.



Read More: [Denmark Reaffirms Greenland’s Sovereignty](#)